

Number, Math and String

Number

1. Introduction: The Unified Number Type

In JavaScript, there is only one type for numbers: `number`. This single type is used to represent both integers (whole numbers like `10`, `-50`) and floating-point numbers (decimals like `3.14`, `-0.5`).

The Core Standard: All numbers in JavaScript are implemented as **64-bit double-precision floating-point numbers**, following the international **IEEE 754 standard**. This is the same format used for `double` in languages like C++ and Java.

```
let integer = 100;
let float = 99.5;

console.log(typeof integer); // "number"
console.log(typeof float);  // "number"
```

2. Creating Numbers

You can create numbers in several ways:

- **Standard Literals:**

```
let a = 25;    // Integer
let b = 12.34; // Floating-point
```

- **Exponential Notation (`e`):** A shorthand for writing very large or very small numbers.

```
let billion = 1e9; // 1 followed by 9 zeros → 1000000000
```

```
let tiny = 5e-6; // 5 / 10^6 → 0.000005
```

- **Other Bases (Hex, Binary, Octal):** You can also represent numbers in other numeral systems.

```
let hex = 0xFF; // Hexadecimal (base 16) → 255 in decimal  
let binary = 0b1010; // Binary (base 2) → 10 in decimal  
let octal = 0o77; // Octal (base 8) → 63 in decimal
```

3. The "Gotcha": Floating-Point Inaccuracy

Because numbers are stored in a binary floating-point format (base-2), they cannot perfectly represent all decimal fractions (base-10). This leads to the most famous "gotcha" in JavaScript math.

```
console.log(0.1 + 0.2); // Outputs: 0.30000000000000004  
console.log(0.1 + 0.2 === 0.3); // false
```

Why? The numbers `0.1` and `0.2` (and `0.3`) have infinitely repeating representations in binary, similar to how `1/3` is `0.333...` in decimal. The computer has to round them off to fit them into the 64-bit storage. These tiny rounding errors accumulate.

How to handle this:

1. **For financial calculations:** Never use floating-point numbers. Work with integers (e.g., store money in cents).
2. **For display:** Use the `.toFixed()` method to round the result to a specific number of decimal places.
3. **For comparison:** Check if two numbers are "close enough" using `Number.EPSILON`.

4. Special Numeric Values

There are three special values that are technically of type `number`.

- **Infinity**: Represents a value larger than the largest possible number. It results from division by zero or exceeding `Number.MAX_VALUE`.

```
console.log(1 / 0);      // Infinity
console.log(-1 / 0);     // -Infinity
console.log(typeof Infinity); // "number"
```

- **Infinity** : Represents a value smaller than the smallest possible number.
- **NaN (Not a Number)**: Represents the result of an invalid or undefined mathematical operation. It's the error code for failed math.**Key Property of NaN** : It is the only value in JavaScript that is not equal to itself.

```
console.log("hello" / 2); // NaN
console.log(Math.sqrt(-1)); // NaN
console.log(typeof NaN); // "number"
```

```
console.log(NaN === NaN); // false
```

5. Important **Number** Properties and Methods

The **Number** object provides several useful constants and methods.

A. **Number** Constants (Limits of the Type)

- **Number.MAX_VALUE** : The largest positive number that can be represented (~1.8e+308).
- **Number.MIN_VALUE** : The smallest positive number closest to zero.
- **Number.MAX_SAFE_INTEGER** : The largest integer that can be safely represented without losing precision ($2^{53} - 1$). **This is the one you should care about for integer math.**
- **Number.MIN_SAFE_INTEGER** : The smallest safe integer.
- **Number.EPSILON** : The smallest interval between two representable numbers. Used for floating-point comparisons.

B. Checking Number Types

- `isNaN(value)` **(Global function)**: The classic way to check if a value is `NaN`.
Gotcha: It coerces the value first, so `isNaN("hello")` is `true`, which can be misleading.
- `Number.isNaN(value)` **(Modern - ES6)**: The better, more reliable way. It returns `true` **only if** the value is actually `NaN`. It does not perform type coercion.

```
isNaN("blue");    // true (coerces "blue" to NaN)
Number.isNaN("blue"); // false (it's a string, not NaN)

let result = 0 / 0; // result is NaN
isNaN(result);    // true
Number.isNaN(result); // true
```

- `isFinite(value)` / `Number.isFinite(value)`: Checks if a value is a real, finite number (not `Infinity`, `-Infinity`, or `NaN`). The `Number.isFinite()` version is stricter and does not coerce.
- `Number.isInteger(value)`: Checks if a value is an integer.

C. Formatting and Converting Numbers

These methods are called on a number variable.

- `.toString(base)`: Converts a number to a string. You can optionally provide a base (from 2 to 36).

```
let num = 255;
console.log(num.toString()); // "255" (base 10 - default)
console.log(num.toString(16)); // "ff" (base 16 - hexadecimal)
console.log(num.toString(2)); // "1111111" (base 2 - binary)
```

- `.toFixed(digits)`: Formats a number to a fixed number of decimal places and returns a **string**. Useful for formatting currency.

```
let price = 19.991234;
console.log(price.toFixed(2)); // "19.99"
```

- `.toFixed(digits)` : Formats a number to a specified total number of significant digits and returns a **string**.

```
let n = 123.456;  
console.log(n.toFixed(4)); // "123.5" (4 significant digits)
```

6. The `Math` Object

JavaScript provides a built-in `Math` object that has properties and methods for mathematical constants and functions. It is not a constructor; you use it directly.

- **Constants:** `Math.PI` , `Math.E`
- **Rounding:**
 - `Math.round(x)` : Standard rounding to the nearest integer.
 - `Math.floor(x)` : Rounds **down** to the nearest integer.
 - `Math.ceil(x)` : Rounds **up** to the nearest integer.
 - `Math.trunc(x)` : Removes the decimal part, leaving only the integer (truncates toward zero).
- **Other Common Functions:**
 - `Math.abs(x)` : Absolute value.
 - `Math.pow(x, y)` : `x` to the power of `y` (same as `x ** y`).
 - `Math.sqrt(x)` : Square root.
 - `Math.max(a, b, c...)` : Returns the largest of the given numbers.
 - `Math.min(a, b, c...)` : Returns the smallest.
 - `Math.random()` : Returns a pseudo-random number between 0 (inclusive) and 1 (exclusive).

```
console.log(Math.round(4.7)); // 5  
console.log(Math.floor(4.7)); // 4  
console.log(Math.ceil(4.2)); // 5
```

```
console.log(Math.max(10, -5, 100, 0)); // 100

// To get a random integer between 1 and 10 (inclusive):
let randomInt = Math.floor(Math.random() * 10) + 1;
```

The Core Tool: `Math.random()`

JavaScript's only built-in tool for randomness is `Math.random()`. You must understand its behavior perfectly to build anything else.

`Math.random()` returns a random floating-point number between `0` (inclusive) and `1` (exclusive).

This means it can return `0`, `0.1234`, `0.5`, `0.99999`, but it will **never** return `1.0`.

- Range: `[0, 1)`

The Goal: A Random Integer Between `min` and `max` (Inclusive)

Let's say our goal is to get a random whole number from 1 to 10. We want `1`, `2`, `3`, ..., `9`, `10`.

The formula to achieve this is:

```
Math.floor(Math.random() * (max - min + 1)) + min
```

This looks complicated, so let's build it up step-by-step to understand the intuition.

Building the Formula from First Principles

Let's stick with our goal: a random integer between `1` (`min`) and `10` (`max`).

Step 1: Scale up the range.

`Math.random()` gives us a number between `0` and `1` (e.g., `0.5`). We want a number in a much larger range. How many different numbers do we want to be able to generate?

1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10

There are **10** possible outcomes.

The number of outcomes is always $\text{max} - \text{min} + 1$.

$10 - 1 + 1 = 10$.

So, the first step is to scale our $[0, 1)$ range up to a range of the correct size. We do this by multiplying.

```
Math.random() * 10;
```

- The lowest possible value is $0 * 10 = 0$.
- The highest possible value is $0.999... * 10 = 9.999...$.
- **Our new range is $[0, 10)$.**

This gives us a floating-point number from 0 up to (but not including) 10 .

Step 2: Get rid of the decimals.

We want whole numbers (integers). The perfect tool for this is `Math.floor()`, which always rounds **down** to the nearest whole number.

Let's see what happens when we apply `Math.floor()` to our range $[0, 10)$:

```
Math.floor(Math.random() * 10);
```

- If `Math.random()` was 0.0 , `Math.floor(0)` is 0 .
- If `Math.random()` was 0.123 , `Math.floor(1.23)` is 1 .
- If `Math.random()` was 0.999 , `Math.floor(9.99)` is 9 .

Applying `Math.floor()` has transformed our float range $[0, 10)$ into an integer range of $0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9$.

This is close! We have 10 possible numbers, but the range is wrong. We want 1 to 10 , not 0 to 9 .

Step 3: Shift the range to the correct starting point.

Our current range is $[0, 9]$. We want $[1, 10]$.

How do you get from 0 to 1? You add 1.

How do you get from 9 to 10? You add 1.

The final step is to shift our entire range up by adding our desired minimum value (`min`).

```
Math.floor(Math.random() * 10) + 1;
```

Let's trace the outcomes:

- If the `Math.floor()` part gave us `0`, the result is `0 + 1 = 1`.
- If the `Math.floor()` part gave us `9`, the result is `9 + 1 = 10`.

This formula now correctly produces a random integer from **1 to 10, inclusive**.

The General-Purpose Function

By replacing the specific numbers `10` and `1` with `max` and `min`, we get our general-purpose formula.

```
/**
 * Generates a random integer between a minimum and maximum value (inclusive).
 * @param {number} min The minimum possible value.
 * @param {number} max The maximum possible value.
 * @returns {number} A random integer within the range.
 */
function getRandomInt(min, max) {
  // 1. Calculate the number of possible outcomes (the size of our range).
  const range = max - min + 1;

  // 2. Scale up Math.random() to create a float in the range [0, range).
  const scaled = Math.random() * range;

  // 3. Round down to get an integer in the range [0, range-1].
  const floored = Math.floor(scaled);

  // 4. Shift the range up to [min, max] by adding the minimum value.
```



```
const result = floored + min;

return result;
}

// Example usage:
console.log("Random number between 1 and 10:", getRandomInt(1, 10));
console.log("Random number between 50 and 100:", getRandomInt(50, 100));
console.log("Random dice roll (1 to 6):", getRandomInt(1, 6));
```

This function encapsulates the logic perfectly and can be reused anywhere in your project.

